

Coinneach Odhar, Am Fiosaiche

D. B. Blair

An abstract geometric pattern composed of various shapes including triangles, squares, diamonds, and lines in shades of blue, green, and yellow, set against a black background.

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ODHAR, AM FIOSAICHE ***

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Coinneach Odhar,

AM FIOSAICHE

Leis an Urr. D. B. Blair, D. D. nach maireann.

SYDNEY, C. B.: "MAC-TALLA" OFFICE 1900

[Ath-Sgrìobhadh an leabhar seo do leabhar-d le Lee Ramsay <l.c.ramsay.07@aberdeen.ac.uk> anns an Chèitean '09. 'S docha gu bhiel na loidnichean beagan diofraichte, ach tha àireamh na duilleagan ceart gu leòr. —'S ann anns na braicaidean no air am mullach a' duilleige a tha iad.]

ROIMH-RADH

Cha 'n eil ach duin' ainneamh am measg nan Gàidheal nach cuala bheag no mhór mu Choinneach Odhar, ach tha ùine cho fada o'n bha e ann—mu dha cheud gu leth bliadhna—'s gu bheil eachdraidh a bheatha agus na fiosachdan a rinn e a dol ann an tomhas mor á cuimhne. Chuir an sàr Ghàidheal, Alasdair Mac Coinnich, a mach leabhar beag Beurla mu thimchioll an fhiosaiche ainmeil so anns a bhliadhna 1877,—leabhar a fhuair deagh ainm aig an àm, agus a bha air a chur an clò uair no dha an deigh sin. Tha an eachdraidh ghorid a th' anns an leabhran so o pheann an Urr. D. B. Blair, D.D., nach maireann, aon de na sgoilearan Gàilig a b' fhearr a bha riamh anns an dùthaich so. Bha i air a clo-bhualadh anns a MHAC-TALLA 'sa bhliadhna 1893, 'nuair a bha 'm paipear sin air ùr-thòiseachadh. Thatar ga 'cur a mach anns a chruth so an dràsda an dòchas gu 'n taitinn i ris na Gàidheil aig am bheil gràdh do chainnt agus do eachdraidh an sinnsear; agus ma nochdas iad an tlachd de 'n oidheirp le bhi ceannach an leabhraich, gabhar misneach gu leabhraichean Gàilig eile a chur a mach o àm gu àm.

Coinneach Odhar, Am Fiosaiche. ——— Anns an àm a chaidh seachad b' àbhaist do na Gàidheil agus do mhuinntir eile a bhi creidsinn gu mor ann an "Taibhsearachd," no an "Da shealladh," mar a theireadh iad. Bho cheann trì fichead bliadhna agus a deich, nuair a bha an sgrìobhadair so 'na ghiullan beag, ann am Mùideart, ann an Gleann-Alladail, a' fuireach anns an taigh far an do chaidil Prionnsa Tearlach, nuair a bha e air a thurus gu Gleann-Fhionghain, far an do chuir e suas a' bhratach ri crann anns a' bhliadhna 1745, is iomad sgiala agus beulradh a chual' e mu dheibhinn taibhsearachd; oir, bha taibhsearan ann am Mùid-eart glé lionmhor aig an àm sin. Ann an {2} Lochabar, an deidh dha Mùideart fhàgail, bu tric a chual e iomradh air Coinneach Odhar, am Fiosaiche,—Taibhsear ainmeil a bha bho shean ann an taobh tuath na h-Alba. Theagamh nach cuala moran de na Gàidheil a rugadh anns an dùthaich so mu thimchioll; agus air son fiosrachaidh dhaibhsan, faodar beagan aithris an so, a réir a' chùinntais a chuir Mr. Alastair Mac Coinnich a mach mu dheibhinn anns an leabhar a sgrìobh e uime.

Rugadh Coinneach Mac Coinnich, no Coinneach Odhar, ann am Baile-na-Cille, an Sgìreachd Uig, an Eilean Leodhais, mu thoiseach na seachdamh linn diag, mu 'n àm anns an robh Seumas-a-sia bho Albainn, no Seumas-a-h-aon air Sassun, 'na rìgh air Breatuinn, agus air Eirinn us Manainn. Cha 'n 'eil a bheag sam bith air chuimhne mu laithean 'òige, ach a mhàin nuair a bha e anns na deugan, mu 'n robh e fichead bliadhna dh' aois, gu 'n d' fhuair e Clach na Fiosachd, leis am b'urrainn da innseadh ciod a thachradh san àm ri tighinn. Fhuair e a' chlach air an dòigh so, mar their cuid:—Bha {3} a' mhàthair feasgar àraid, a reir a' bheulraite, a' buachailleachd a' chruidh air an àiridh, air leacuinn aonaich ris an abairteadh Cnoc-Eothail, os cionn cladh Baile-na-Cille, an Uig. Mu mharbh mheadon oidhche chunnaic i a h-uile uaigh sa' chladh a' fosgladh, agus dòmhlas mor sluaigh ag eiridh as na

h-uaighibh, beag us mor, sean us og, bho 'n naoidhean gus an sean-athair liath, agus a' falbh gach rathad as a' chladh. An ceann uarach de thim thill iad air an ais, agus chaidh iad a staigh do na h-uaighibh a rithist, agus dhùin gach uaidh mar a bha i roimhe. Thainig màthair Choinnich am fagus do 'n chladh, agus thug i fainear aon uaigh a bha fosgailte fhathast. A chionn gu 'm bu bhoirionnach dalma, smioral i, chuir i roimpe gum biodh fios aice c'arson a bha an uaigh so fosgailte nuair a dhùineadh càch. Ruith i agus chuir i a' Chuigeal tarsuinn air beul na h-uaghaich (oir chual i nach b' urrainn do 'n spiorad dol air ais a steach do 'n uaigh, cho fhad 's a bhiodh a' chuigeal tarsuinn oirre). An ceann beagan ùine thainig rìbhinn àluinn, a' snamh {4} troimh 'n iarmailt bho thuath, a dh' ionnsuidh a' chlaidh. Air teachd dhi thubhairt i ris a' mhnaoi, "Tog do chuigeal bharr m' uaigh, agus leig dhomh dol air m' ais gu m' àros." "Ni mi sin," Arsa an te eile, "ma dh' innseas tu dhomh ciod e a chum thu air dheireadh air càch." Fhreagair an taibhse, "Innsidh mi sin duit gun dàil. Bha mo thuras na b' fhaide na turais chàich; oir bha agam ri dhol do Lochluinn-a-Tuath (Norway). Is mise nighean Rìgh Lochluinn; bhàthadh mi nuair a bha mi 'gam fhairigeadh san tir sin; thainig mo chorp gu tir air a' chladach so sios fodhainn, agus thiodhlaiceadh mi anns an uaigh so. Mar chuimhneachan ormsa, agus mar dhuais dhuit fhèin airson do threun-mhisnich, bheir mi dhuit falachan sonruichte luachmhor,—falbh agus sir, us gheibh thu anns an loch ud thall clach bheag, chruinn, ghorm; thoir i sin do d' mhac, Coinneach, agus leatha innsidh esan nithean a thacras an deidh an àm so." Rinn i mar a dh' iarraidh oirre, fhuair i a' chlach, agus thug i seachad i do Choinneach a mac. Cha bu luaithe fhuair e a' {5} chlach na thainig feart na fiosachd uige, agus sgaoileadh a chliù mar fhiosaiche air feadh na dùthcha. Bhiodh uaislean us islean a' taghal air agus a' tighinn thuige air son fiosachd.

Ach tha iomad beulraite eile mu 'n dòigh anns an d' fhuair Coinneach a' chlach. Tha aon ag radh, gun robh e 'na sheirbhiseach aig tuathanach, agus gun robh diumb aig bean an tuathanaich ris air son a bhriathran beurra,

sgeigeil. Air latha sònruichte bha e a' gearradh mòine leis an torraisgein fada bho 'n tigh, agus b' eigin an dinneir a chur thuige; chur bean an tuathanaich puinnsean anns an dinneir gu cur as da. Ach mu 'n d' thainig an dinneir shuidh e leigeil analach agus thuit e 'na chadal. Dhùisgeadh e le cabhaig; oir dh' fhairich e rud fuar air a bhroilleach. Chuir e làmh air, agus fhuair e clach bheag, gheal, agus toll 'na teis-meadhain. Sheall e troimh 'n toll agus chunnaic e sealladh air ais-innleachd na bana-mhaighstir. Thug e an dinneir do 'n chù, agus fhuair an cù am bàs gu dòruinneach.

Tha beulraite eile ag radh gun robh e a' {6} gearradh mòine, agus gun do shuidh e gu anail a leigeil a' feitheamh gus an tigeadh a bhean fèin d'a ionnsuidh leis an dinneir. Thuit e 'na chadal, agus nuair a dhùisg e dh' fhairich e rud cruaidh f'a cheann; fhuair e an sin clach bheag, chruinn, agus toll troimh a meadhon. Thog e i agus sheall e troimh an toll; chunnaic e a' bhean aige fhèin a' tighinn d'a ionnsuidh le dinneir cabhruich agus bainne, air a puinnseanachadh, gun fhios di-se, le a bana-mhaighstir. Ach ged a fhuair Coinneach feart na fiosachd leis a' chloich, chaill e sealladh na sùla leis an d' amhairc e troimh an toll, agus bha e riamh tuilleadh cam, no aon-suileach, an deigh sin.

Tha Aoidh no Uisdean Muillear ag radh anns an leabhar aige, "Scenes and Legends," gun d' thainig a bhana-mhaighstir d'a ionnsuidh le dinneir phuinnseanaichte; fhuair i e 'na chadal air mullach sithein, agus an aite dhùsgadh, chaill i a misneach; dh' fhàg i am meadar, no a' mhias, ri a thaobh, agus thill i dhachaidh. Dhùisg esan; ach mu 'n do ghabh e an dinneir dh' fhairich e rud cruaidh 'na {7} bhroilleach: chuir e làmh air agus thug e mach clachag chruinn, boidheach, leis an d' fhuair e fios mu 'n droch cleas a rinn a bhana-mhaighstir air.

A reir gach ràite tha e coltach gun robh a' chlach ann, agus gun robh Coinneach 'ga cleachdadh gu bhi toirt a chreidsinn air an t-sluagh fiosachd a

bhi aige. Cha'n 'eil sinne a' creidsinn gun robh feart fiosachd air bith anns a' chloich, ged a dh' fhaodadh i bhi 'na cloich mhìn, bhòidhich, ghorm-gheil, agus toll innte cuideachd, coltach ri clachan bòidheach a chunnaic sinn air cladach I-Challum-Chille, agus Eilean Mhuile.

Nuair a fhuair Coinneach clach na fiosachd, sgaoileadh a chliù feadh na tire mar fhiosaiche, agus bhiodh feadhainn a' tighinn thuige as gach àite air son fios fhaotainn mu thimchioll na teachd-ùine. Mu thimchioll ciad gu leth bliadhna mu 'n do rinneadh an t-slighe-uisge, no an caolas-cladhaichte, eadar Inbhear-Nis agus Inbhear-Lòchaidh, (an Caledonian Canal,) thuirt Coinneach, "Ged is ioghnadh leibhse an diugh e, thig an latha, 's cha 'n 'eil {8} e fad as, anns am faicear làraichean Sasunnach ('s e sin longan) air an tarruing le srianan còrcaich seachad air cul Tom-na-h-Iuraich." Thuirt e mar an ciadna, "Thig an latha anns am bi rathad mor troimh bheanntan Rois, o mhuir gu muir agus drochaid air gach allt," no "Ribeann air gach cnoc agus drochaid air gach alltan." Mar an ciadna, "Thig an latha anns an lion na caoraich mhora an tir, gus am buail iad a' mhuir gu tuath." "Bidh muileann air gach abhuinn, agus taigh geal air gach cnocan." "Bidh criosan guaille tarsuinn air gach sliabh." "Thig bo mhaol odhar a stigh an t-Aite mor, agus leigidh i geum aiste a chuireas na sia beannagan dhe an Taigh-Dhige." Saoilear gur bàta-smùid a tha e ciallachadh. So fiosachd eile, "Thig an latha anns an cur peirceall nan caorach mora an crann air an fharadh. Nuair bhios na caoirich mhor cho lionmhor us gun cluinnear mèilich an dara té dhiubh leis an té eile, bho Chonachra, ann an Loch-Aillse, gu Bun-da-Loch, an Ceann-Taile, bidh iad aig an àirde 'nam pris, agus an deigh sin theid {9} iad air an ais gus am falbh iad uile as an t-sealladh, agus theid iad air diochuimhne cho mor as nach aithnichear peirceall caorach a gheibhear air carn, no ciod am beathach d' am buineadh e. Falbhaidh na seann Tighearnan as an tir, agus thig ceannaichean Gallda 'nan àite, agus bidh a' hàidhealtachd uile gu léir 'na h-aon fhrith mhor fhiadh. Bhidh an dùthaich cho gann de shluagh, agus cho fàs, as nach cluinnear gairm coilich gu tuath air Druim

Uachdair. Theid an sluagh air imrich gu eileanaibh cian, nach fhaicear an diugh, ach a gheibhear a mach anns a' Chuan Mhor. An deigh sin sgriosar agus bathar na féidh, agus na fiadh bheistean eile leis na siantan dubha. Thig an sluagh an sin air an ais agus gabhaid iad seilbh air fearann an sinnsearach." Fiosachd eile, "Theid na Gàidheil gu America, ach thig iad air an ais fhathast gus an tir fhéin." Mu thimchioll Mhic Leòid Rathasaidh so fiosachd, "Nuair a thig Mac Dhomhnuill Duibh ban, Mac Shimidh ceann-dearg, Siosalach claon ruadh, Mac Coinnich mor bodhar, agus Mac Gille-Challum cam-chasach, {10} iad ogha Iain bhig a Ruigeath, se sin am Mac Gille-Challum a's miosa thainig na thig; cha bhi mi ann ri a linn, 's cha 'n fhear leam air a bhith." Thachair an ni so; oir b'e am Mac Gille-Challum so, iar-ogha Iain bhig a Ruigeath, agus bha e cho strudheasach us gun do chaith e oighreachd a shinnsirean; agus bha na Tigh-earnan eile chaidh ainmeachadh, 'nan comhaoisean do Mhac Gille-Challum so, leis na comharan orra a dh' innis am fiosaiche.

So fiosachd eile, "Nuair a thraoghas abhainn na Manachinn tri uairean, agus a ghlacar Bradan Sligeach air grunn na h-aibhne, is ann an sin a bhitheas an diachainn ghoirt." Thiormaich abhainn na Manachainn cheana da uair,—an uair mu dheireadh air a' bhliadhna 1826, nuair a bha tiormachd mhor ann; chaidh a' choile 'na teine ann am Miramichi, agus loisgeadh moran thaighean ann mar an ciadna; agus bho cheann sia bliadhna diag ghlacadh 'Bradán Sligeach,' no Stirean no Stiorrach (Sturgeon) ann an grunn na h-aibhne. "Fàsaidh an sluagh cho {11} tais us gun teich iad as an dùthaich roimh armailt chaorach." Chuireadh an tir fo chaoirich, agus dh' fhalbh an sluagh.

Rinn Coinneach fiosachd chomharraichte mu thimchioll Clann Choinnich an Uillt-Bhoidhich (Fairburn), agus Caisteal no Tur an Uillt-Bhoidhich (Fairburn Tower). "Thig an latha anns an caill Clann Choinnich an Uillt-Bhoidhich am fearann uile, agus theid am meur sin de 'n fhine as an t-

sealladh gus nach fàgar duine dhiubh air aghaidh na talmhainn. Bidh an caisteal fàs, air a threigsinn, gun duine 'ga aiteachadh no gabhail comhnuidh ann; agus beiridh bo laogh ann an seomar uachdrach an Tùir." Thachair na nithean so uile do reir na fiosachd. Chaill an teaghlach sin de Chloinn Choinnich an seilbhean gu h-iomlan; agus rug a bhò an laogh mar a dh'innseadh, san t-seomar uachdrach. Bho cheann beagan bhliadhnachan chaidh an Tùr fhagail na fhàsaich; ghrod na dorsan agus thuit iad dheth, fear an deigh fir, gus mu dheireadh nach robh dorus idir air an staidhir mhoir shniomhain a bha ruigsinn bho 'n bhonn gu mhullach. {12} Bha 'n staidhir so de chlioch agus mar sin seasmhach, maireannach. Bho cheann beagan ùine thaisg an tuathanach aig an robh a' gabhail fodar ann an seòmar uachdrach an Tùir. Thuit pàirt de 'n fhodar air an staidhir mar a bha iad 'ga ghiùlan an àird. Thainig te de 'n chrodh air latha àraid a dh'ionnsuidh dorus an Tùir, agus air do 'n dorus a bhi fosgailte, chaidh i staigh agus thòisich i air trusadh agus itheadh nan sraibhlean a bha sgapte thall 's a bhos air an staidhir. Lean i mar so a' dol air a h-adhart bho cheum gu ceum de 'n staidhir gus an d'rainig i am mullach,—chaidh i staigh do 'n t-seòmar ag itheadh nan sraibhlean roimpe, agus air dhi bhi trom le laogh cha b' urrainn i tearnadh air a h-ais; uime sin dh'fhàg iad i anns an t-seòmar gus an do rub i an laogh, a bha 'na chreutar fallain, bòidheach. Dh'fhàg iad a' bho agus an laogh car ùine shònruichte anns an t-seòmar agus chaidh iomadh neach a mach á Inbhirnis gus am faicinn. Mar so bha faisneachd Choinnich air a coilionadh gus an dearbh litir.

{13}

Thuir Coinneach "Beirear nighean mhaol dubh air cùl Eaglais Ghearrloch." Thachair so; aig cruinneachadh sluaigh, saothair-chloinne gu h-obann air mnaoi òig, a bha anns an éisdeachd aig cùl na h-Eaglais, agus mum b' urrainn dhaibh a ghiùlan air falbh as an àite, rug i an "nighean mhaol dhubh." Tha sliochd na h-ighinn maoile dhuibhe so ri fhaicinn, agus ri

fhaotainn, gus an latha an diugh ann an Gearloch; agus mar so tha fiosachd Choinnich air teachd gu crìch.

Rinn Coinneach fiosachd mu Mhac Leòid Dhun-bheagain: "Nuair a gheibh Tormaid nan Tri Tormaid, mac na mnatha caoile cruaidhe Sasunnaich, bàs le sgiorradh; nuair a reicear Maighdeannan Mhic Leòid ri fear de na Caimbeulaich; nuair a bheireas galla-shionnaich cuain chuilean ann an aon de bhinneanaibh a' chaisteil; agus nuair a bheirear air lom a Bhratach Shith an uair mu dheireadh, siùbhlaidh greadhnachas Mhic Leòid air falbh; reicear a' mhor chuid de 'n oighreachd ri coigrich; bidh am fine cho tearc us gun giùlain {14} 'curach beag' thairis air Loch Dhunbheagain na bhios ann de dh' uaislibh de'n chinneadh. Ach ùine mhor, fhada an deigh sin thig 'Iain Breac' eile, agus aisigidh e an oighreachd, agus bidh cliù an taighe na 's àirde na bha e riamh." Thachair cuid de'n fhiosachd so. Mharbhadh Tormaid nan Tri Tormaid, nuair a shèideadh suas le fùdar an long-chogaidh an Queen Charlotte, air an robh e 'na oifeach. Reiceadh na creagan d' am b' ainm "Na Maighdeannan" ri Aonghas Caimbeul, agus tha iad fhathast aig ogha dha mar sheilibh. Bha peata sionnaich aig Caipitean Mac Gilleain, a bha fuireach ann am mullach a' Chaisteil, agus rug i cuain chuilean; agus chunnaic agus laimhsich Dr. Mach Leòid, Tormaid mor Gaidhealach an Teachdaire, na cuileanan, air a bhliadhna 1799, air dha bhi ann an Caisteal Dhunn-bheagain, 'san Eilean Sgiathanach. Chunnaic e mar an ciadna aig an àm sin "Bratach Shith" Mhic Leòid 'ga toirt air lom as a' chist iarunn san robh i an tasgadh, air a dùnadh suas ann am bocsa fiodha chùbhraidh, deagh-bholtrach. Bha {15} 'bhratach na mir ceithir-chearnach de shioda luachmhor air fhigheadh le croisean tarsuinn de shnàthuinnibh òir. Tha chuid eile de 'n fhàisneachd ri tighinn, ma thig i idir.

Bheir sinn fainear a nis mar a thainig crìoch a bheatha air Coinneach Odhar. Ri linn Rìgh Tearlach II., an deidh dha bhi air aiseag a chum a' chrùin agus na rìgh-chathrach, chaidh Iarla Shi-phort, Coinneach, an treas

Iarla, air teachdaireachd gu Paris, baile mor na Frainge, agus dh' fhàg e a' Bhan-Iarla aig an taigh ann an Caisteal Bhrathainn. Dh' fhuraich an t-Iarla ùine fhada ann am Paris, agus thòisich a' Bhan-Iarla air gabhail fadail agus iogh-naidh nach robh e a' tighinn dachaidh. Ma dheireadh thall chaill i a foighidinn agus chuir i fios air Coinneach Odhar gus an innseadh e rud-eigin di mu thimchioll an Iarla. Thainig Coinneach a dh'ionnsuidh Caisteal Bhrathainn, agus dh'fhoighneachd a'Bhan-Iarla dheth am b'urrainn da innseadh cia dhiubh a bha an t-Iarla beò no marbh. Chuir Coinneach Clach na Fiosachd ri shùil, agus le àrd ghàireachdaich {16} labharr, thuirt e ris a' Bhan Iarla, "Na biodh eagal sam bith ort mu thimchioll an Iarla' tha e slàn, fallain, tearuinte, cridheil, mireagach, sùnnnach." Dh' fheòraich a' Bhan-Iarla an sin ciod a bha e deanamh agus co bha timchioll air. Thubhairt Coinneach rithe,—"Gu ma leòr" leat na chaidh innseadh; na farraidh ceist air bith; bi toilichte le fios gum bheil am morair slàn agus sùnnnach." "Ach," ars' ise, "cait am bheil e? Co leis a tha e? agus am bheil e deanamh deisealachd air son tighinn dachaidh?" Thubhairt am fiosaiche, "Tha am morair ann an seòmar mor greadhnach, ann am measg cuideadhd grinn, agus ri aighear 'us mire, ionnus nach 'eil guth aige air baile mor na Frainge fhagail aig an àm so." Ach cha bu leòr am freagradh so leis a' Bhan-Iarla; chuir i thuige Coinneach gus an innseadh e an t-iomlan mu thimchioll a fir. Ghuidh i le griosadan, thairg i duaisean, agus mhaidh i air le bagraidh, gus an innseadh e na b'aithne dha. Air do Choinneach e fhéin a chaisleachadh agus a chloimhdeachadh, thubhairt e rithe, "Bho 'n is àill leat {17} fios fhaotainn air na dh' fhagas mi thoilichte thu, is eigin domh an fhirinn innseadh dhuit. Is beag smuain a tha aig Morair Mac Coinnich ort fhéin, no air a chlainn, no air a dhachaidh anns a' Ghàidhealtachd. Chunnaic mis' e ann an seòmar òraichte, air a chòmhdach le bheibheid, sìoda agus aodach òir; bha e air a ghlùinean air beulaobh ribhinn mhaisich, a làmh timchioll air a cneas, agus a làmh-se air a bhilean." Nuair a chual' a Bhan-Iarla so las i le feirg, agus dh' at i suas le h-àrdan. An fhearg a bha nàdurra gu leor an

aghaidh an Iarla, thionndaidh i gu h-eucorach an aghaidh an fhiosaiche. Ghabh i oirre nach robh i creidsinn na fiosachd, agus chuir i roimpe am fiosaiche a chur gu bàs. Thubhairt i ri Coinneach "Labhair thu toibheum mu àrd-inbhe, mhaslaich thu maithean na tire, thug thu tàmailt do cheann-feadhna mor an làthair a chinnidh. Thug thu tàir dhòmhsa agus do'n chaisteal, agus labhair thu gu sgainnealach mu 'n mhorair ann an lùchairt mhoir a shinnsear; air an aobhar sin, is eigin domhsa do chur gu bàs." Ghabh {18} Coinneach iongantas agus uamhas nuair a chual' e na briathran a labhair a Bhan-Iarla, a bha na bain-diabhul cruaidh-chridheach, an-ìochdmhor, gun tròcair. Shaoil leis an fhiosaiche gur h-ann a gheibheadh e duais air son 'fhiosachd, ach b'e an duais a fhuair e am bàs. Dh' òrduich am boirionnach mallaichte a thoirt a mach gu bhi air a losgadh ann am baraille tearra aig a' Chananaich, le òrdugh Easbuig Rois, dhe 'n Eaglais Easbuighich Albannaich.

Tha beulraite eile a' tabhairt cunntais eadar-dhealaichte mu aobhar feirge na Ban-Iarla ri Coinneach Odhar. Aig àm àraid, a reir an iomraidh, bha cuirm mhòr agus cruinneachadh lionmhor a dh' uaislean ann an caisteal Bhrathainn. Bha òigridh nan àrd uaislean 'gan cluich fhéin air a' bhlàr a muigh, air an àilean ghorm, timchioll a'chaisteil Thubhairt cuideigin ann an èisdeachd Choinnich, gum b' ainneamh a chiteadh tional cho lionmhor de chlainn dhaoine uaisle. Fhreagair Coinneach gu sgallaiseach, "Is mo a th' ann de chlainn ghilleann-bùird, agus de {19} chlainn ghilleann-stàpuill, na th' ann de chlainn dhaoine uaisle." Tha beulraite eile ag radh, gur h-ann a bha an òigridh a' dannsadh ann an lùchairt mhoir a' chaisteil an àite bhi 'gan cluich air an àilean, nuair a labhair Coinneach gu fanaideach umpa. Dh'aithriseadh briathran Choinnich do 'n Bhan-Iarla, agus ghabh i fhéin 's na baintighearnan eile fearg ris, air son a bhi cur an amharus deagh-bheusan agus teisteachd mhnathan uaisle Rois, agus a' toirt mi-chliù follaiseach orra mar sud. Dh' òrduich i am fiosaiche a ghlacadh gun dàil; agus ged a theich e gu fhalach féin car tamuill, fhuaradh a mach mu dheireadh far an

robh e. Nuair a chunnaic e nach robh dol as aige bho a naimhdidh, chuir e clach na fiosachd ri shùil agus thubhairt e, "Chi mi fada romham, agus is leur dhomh am breitheanas a thig air sliochd mo luchd-sàrachaidh. Bidh seann teaghlach Iarla Shi-phort air an ditheachadh gu tur, mun teid moran linnean seachad. Chi mi ceann-feadhna, am fear mu dheireadh d'a theaghlach, araon bodhar agus balbh. Bidh ceathrar mhac àluinn aige, {20} ach theid iad uile roimhe fhèin do'n uaigh. Caithidh e a bheatha gu h-iomaguineach, agus gheibh e am bàs gu brònach, a' caoidh gum bi sliochd a shinnsear air an dubhadh a mach gu bràth, agus nach bi Mac Coinnich tuilleadh ri fhaotainn 'na Thighearna air Caisteal Bhrathainn, no air Ceann-Tàile. An deigh dha bròn a dheanamh air son an fhir mu dheireadh d'a chuid mac, am fear bu taitniche dhiubh, siubhlaidh e fhéin, a' dol do 'n eug, agus bidh an oighreachd aige air a' sealbhachadh le caileag air am bi currachd bàn, a thig bho 'n àirde 'n ear, d' am bi e 'n dàn a piuthar a mharbhadh. Mar chomharra gun tachair so, bidh ceathrar thighearnan air am bi suaicheantas 'nan comh-aioisean do Iarla Shi-phort mu dheireadh, a bhios bodhar, agus balbh; se sin Tighearna Storach (Stor fhiaclach) Ghearrloch, an Siosalach le milleadh-maighich, an Granndach Gorach, agus Mac-Gille-Chalum Gagach no manndach. Nuair a chi Mac Coinnich Bhrathainn a cheathrar so, tuigear leis gum bheil am bàs an dàn d'a chuid mac; gun teid an oighreachd gu coigrich {21} agus gun dubhar as a theaghlach gu siorruidh, gun fhirionnach d'a shliochd a thogas 'ainm."

Nuair a chrìochnaich am fiosaiche an fhaisneachd so, thilg e clach na fiosachd ann an lochan uisge, no mar a their cuid, ann an lorg coise mairt a bha làn uisge, agus thubhairt e, "Co sam bith a gheibh a' chlach sin, bidh feart na fiosachd aige mar an ciadna." Thubhairt e a bharr air sin, mar tha cuid ag radh, "Beirear leanabh le da imleig, no le ceithir mèir fhichead a reir cuid, gheibh e a' chlach so ann am broinn geadais, agus leis a' chloich thig buaidh na fiosachd thuige." Nuair a thugadh a mach Coinneach gus a losgadh, thuit a' Bhan Iarla ris nach rachadh e do Fhlaitheanas gu siorruidh.

Thionndaidh e mun cuairt agus thubhairt e rithe, "Theid mise do Fhlaitheanas; ach cha teid thusa ann gu siorruidh. So dhuit comharradh leis am faigh thu fios ciod e mo chor san t-saoghal ri teachd. Thig caluman agus fitheach an coinneamh a cheile bho dha thaobh an athair, gus an seas iad os ceann agus an laidh iad air {22} luaithre mo chuirp. Ma thig am fitheach an toiseach labhair thusa an fhirinn, ach ma thig an caluman an toiseach labhair thu breugan, agus tha mo dhochas air deagh bhunait."

Dh' òrduich a' Bhan-Iarla Coinneach a ghlacadh, 's a cheangal, eadar lamhan 'us chasan, agus a ghiulan gu Rugha na Cananaich, far an do thilgeadh e an coinneamh a chinn ann am baraille tearra bha dearg-losgadh, agus air an robh a thaobh a stigh lan spicean fada iarunn, biorach, geur, a bhuaileadh troimhe bho 'n taobh muigh. Rinneadh an ni eagallach so le ùghdarras Easbuig Rois, agus cléir na h-Eaglais Easbuigich, a bha air a suidheachadh aig an àm ud, mar Eaglais na Rioghachd an Albainn, le Rìgh Tearlach a Dha. Air an dearbh latha air an do chuireadh Coinneach air falbh bho Chaisteal Bhrathainn thainig Iarla Shi-phort dhachaidh as an Fhraing, agus dh' innis iad da air ball an ni a rinn a' Bhan-Mhorair mu Choinneach, agus gun robh e nis air a thurus a dh' ionnsuidh na Cananaich le òrdugh na Cléire, gu bhi air a losgadh.{23} Bha deagh fhios aig a' Mhorair air nàdur dioghaltach, ain-iochdmhor na Ban-Iarla. Chreid e gun robh an sgeula fìor, seadh tuilleadh us fìor. Cha d' iarr 's cha do ghabh e biadh no deoch; cha do ghairm e air sgalaig no gille stapuill, ach chaidh e fhein le cabhaig a dh' ionnsuidh an stapuill, chuir e diollaid air an each a b' fhearr a bha 'na ghreigh, leum e air a mhuin, agus dh' fhalbh e leis an each 'na dheann-ruith, 'g a ghreasad cho luath 's a b' urrainn da, an dùil gun ruigeadh e Rugha na Cananaich mun rachadh an t-innleachd diabhlaidh a dheilbh a Bhan-Iarla agus a' chléir Easbuigeach a chur gu buil; cha do mharcaich Iarla Shi-phort riamh roimhe cho luath no cho dian. Ann am beagan ùine bha e am fagus do 'n Chananaich, agus chunnaic e smùid dhubh thiugh ag éirigh suas bho 'n Rugha gu h-iosal. Thainig gairisinn na fheòil, bhrùchd am fallus fuar a

mach troimh a chorp, chuir e spuir ris an each a bha cheana an impis toirt thairis, a chum gun ruigeadh e an t-àite bàis, gu beatha an fhiosaiche a shàbhaladh. Mar uighe beagan shlat bho 'n {24} àite far an robh an smùid ag éirigh, thuit an t-each air an làr agus thug e suas a deò, oir cha b' urrainn da a' chruidh-spàirn a sheasamh na b'fhaide leis mar a bha an t-Iarla 'ga chur thuige 's ga sporadh air adhart. Nuair a chaill e an t-each, ruith an t-Iarla gu dian air a' chois, ag eigheach a mach le àirde a ghuth, ris an t-sluagh a bha cruinn air an Rugha, iad a thearnadh beatha an fhiosaiche. Ach mo thruaighe! bha e tuilleadh us anmoch. Cia dhiu a chuala no nach cuala an sluagh glaodhaich àrd an Iarla, bha Coinneach Odhar air a thilgeadh anns a' bharaille loisgeach beagan mhoinaidean mun do rainig Iarla Shi-phort an t-àite gus a theasairginn.

Air an doigh so chrìochnaich beatha an fhiosaiche, agus cha 'n 'eil e coltach gun rachadh an sgeula ud a dheilbh mu 'bhàs mur tachradh an ni mar a chaidh aithris. Nan d' fhuair Coinneach bàs nàdurra 'na leabaidh, cha ghabh e creidsinn gun rachadh an sgeula truagh ud a dheilbh no chur air chois. Ach ciod a their sinn mu luchd-dreuchd Eaglais a {25} thug gnùis da leithid sud de ghnìomh oillteil, agus a dh' aontaich ris? Bha iad air son a' Bhan-Iarla a thoileachadh gu cinnteach, ach anns na linnibh dorcha sin bha e 'na chleachdadh a bhi losgadh nam buitseach agus nam fiosaichean, agus is iomadh creutair truagh a chuireadh gu bas fo 'n chùis-dhitidh so, aig nach robh tuilleadh buitseachd na tha aig an lair-ghlais, Bheir sinn cùnntas a nise mar a thainig faisneachd Choinnich Uidhir gu teachd mu thimchioll teaghlaich Iarla Shi-phort, faisg air ciad gu leth bliadhna an deigh bhi air a labhairt.

Chunnaic sinn mar a thachair do'n fhiosaiche. Rachamaid a nise agus faiceamaid ciod a thainig gu buil de 'n fhiosachd mu dheibhinn Mhic Choinnich Bhrathainn. Fhuair an t-Iarla a bha ann ri linn Choinnich am bas air a' bhliadhna 1678; fhuair a mhac, an ceathramh Iarla, am bas; chaill an

coigeamh Iarla, mac an fhir so, an oighreachd agus an tiodal chionn gun d' éirich e ann an aobhar Sheumais air a' bhliadhna 1715. Ach dh' aisigeadh an oighreachd dha air a' bhliadhna 1726, agus {26} air a' bhliadhna 1771 fhuair a mhac an tiodal Iarla Shi-phort. Gidheadh bhàsaich an tiodal leis fhéin air a' bhliadhna 1781. Nuair a bhàsaich e cha robh oighre aige, ach fhuair ogha bràthar a shean-athar an oighreachd, a mheal e re dha bhliadhna, oir chaidh a mharbhadh 's na h-Innseachaibh an Ear air a' bhliadhna 1783. Thainig a bhràthair na 'àite, am Mac Coinnich mu dheireadh a bha ann am Brathainn, anns an do choilionadh faisneachd an fhiosaiche.

Rugadh Fraing Mac Coinnich so air a' bhliadhna 1764. Bha uile bhuadhan agus cheud-faithean a chuirp agus 'inntinn aige gun deireas nuair a rugadh e, ach chaill e a chlaistneachd agus dh' fhas e bodhar leis an Teasaich Scarlaid nuair a bha e 'na ghiullan òg a' dol do 'n sgoil sia bliadhna deug a dh'aois. Nuair a dh' fhàs e mor agus a fhuair e oighreachdan Bhrathainn an deidh bàis a bhràthar, chuir e reiseamaid air a cois a chogadh ri Bonapart, air a' bhliadhna 1807, agus fhuair e bhi na Sheanalair air a' bhliadhna 1808. Bha ceathrar mhac aige, ach fhuair fear dhiubh bàs na {27} òige. Dh' fhàs an triuir eile gu bhi nan daoineibh, ach fhuair iad bàs fear an deigh fir, gus nach d'fhàgadh a h-aon diubh beò. Bha am fear mu dheireadh 'na òganach maiseach, gealltanach, aig an robh buadhan inntinn taitneach, ach bhuail eucail throm e, agus chaidh e gu taobh deas Shasuinn air son a shlàinte, far an d' fhuair e bàs. Nuair a fhuair seann Mhac Coinnich sgeula bàis a' mhic cha do labhair e riabh tuilleadh agus dh' fhàs e balbh, oir cha labhradh e facal, cia dhiubh a bha e neo-chomasach no mi-thoileach air bruidhinn. Fhuair e am bàs air an aonamh latha deug de Ianuairidh, 1813, am fear mu dheireadh de a theaghlach.* Thainig an nighean bu shine dhiubhsan a bha beò an àite a h-athar gu seilbh air oighreachd Bhrathainn. Bha i pòsda ris an Ard-mharaiche, Sir Samuel Hood, ceann-feadhna cahbhlaich Bhreatuinn anns na h-Innseachaibh an Iar 's an Ear; ach fhuair e

am bàs san airde 'n Ear 'na dhuine òg; agus mar sin bha a bhean 'na {28} bantraich oig nuair a dh' eug a h-athair. Agus, thainig i dhachaidh as na h-Innseachan le Currachd Ban na bantraich air a ceann, agus b'e Hood a b'ainm dhi. An deigh sin phòs i Mr. Stiùbhart, ogha do Iarla Ghalloway, agus ghabh esan ainm Mhic Coinnich an co-thaice ri anim fein; agus mar sin theirteadh Stiubhart Mac Coinnich ris. Air an dòigh so chaidh oighreachd Bhrathainn thairis bho shliochd nam firionnach ann an seann teaghlach Chinn-Tàile. An deigh sin reic Mr. agus Mrs. Stiùbhart Mac Coinnich eilean Leòdhais ri Sir Seumas Mathanaich. Air latha àraid bha Mrs. Stiùbhart Nic Coinnich ann an carbad sealltaidh no carbad ponaidh. Ghabh na sealltaidhean eagal agus ruith iad air falbh nan still, 's nan deannaibh. Cha b' urrainn a Bhain-tighearna an casg, agus thilgeadh i fhéin agus a piuthar a mach as a' charbad. Chaidh an ciùrradh agus am bruthadh gu goirt: ach leighiseadh a' bhaintighearn ann an ceann beagan ùine, gidheadh fhuair a piuthar a b' òige am bàs leis an dochann a rinneadh oirre. Mar so thainig fàisneachd Choinnich gu {29} crich, agus dh'aobharaich Baintighearna Bhrathainn bàs a peathar, ged nach robh coire aice ris. Bha na ceithir tighearnan eile 'nan comh-aoisibh do Mhac Coinnich, Sir Eachann Ghearrloch, an tighearna storach, an Siosalach, air an robh milleadh maighich, tighearna Ghrannda bha 'na amadan, agus Mac-Gille-Challuim gagach.

Tha sinn a nise toirt na h-eachdraidh ghoirid so gu crich. Chaidh, gun teagamh sam bith, moran de dh' fhiosachdan Choinnich a choilionadh gu litireil, agus tha daoine ann a tha dhe 'n bharail gu 'm bi tuilleadh dhiubh air an coilionadh fhatast, Biodh sin mar a bhitheas, theid iomadh bliadhna 's linn seachad mu 'n sguirear a bhi 'g aithris, am measg nan Gàidheal, gach fiosachd iongantach a rinn e, am bàs uamhasach a dh' fhuiling e, agus mar a thainig an caluman 's a laidh e air a luaithre—an ni a thubhairt Coinneach fhéin a bha gu tachairt, mar chomharradh air gu robh 'anam air a ghiùlan gu Flaitheanas.

A'CHRIOCH

(duilleag 27) * Tha Sir Walter Scott ag radh,

"Cha ghabh fironnach faotainn air strath no air aird,
Thogas suas ainm Mhic Coinnich, ceann-cinnidh Chinn-Tail."

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ODHAR, AM FIOSAICHE ***

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